

[using the 70% threshold gives 92%]. 345 of the 420 have private profiles—with the possible exception of $\mathbf{f}^{35}$ there was no ‘stuffing the ballot box’.

Although $\mathbf{f}^{35}$ obviously falls within the Byzantine stream, I will factor it out and treat it separately. 420 less 80 equals 340 strongly Byzantine MSS, only 25 of which share a profile. We obviously have a text-type, but is it a recension? To posit a recension we need a source—who did it, when and where? And using what? Did he merely edit existing materials or did he invent some of the variants? If he invented, is there an observable pattern to explain his attitude?

We have 315 strongly Byzantine MSS (without $\mathbf{f}^{35}$) with private profiles—they are independent in their own generation, presumably representing as many exemplars, also presumably independent in their own generation, etc. Which is at least partly why scholars from Hort to Aland have recognized that any Byzantine ‘recension’ could not have been created later than the 4th century.

As a preliminary to taking up the question of $\mathbf{f}^{35}$ ($\mathbf{K}^r$) as possibly a recension, I wish to consider other aspects of the general evidence presented in *TuT*. Of the MSS that were collated, 78 are dated. There are nine pairs of MSS with the same date (but no more than two MSS to a year—so 60 have a private year); in eight of them the two MSS are quite different in profile; in the ninth pair both MSS are $\mathbf{f}^{35}$ but differ in one variant. Both are at Mt. Athos, but in different monasteries—it is highly improbable that they had the same exemplar. There is no evidence here of mass production. But why would a monk on Mt. Athos produce a copy in 1280 AD? If the copy is still there, it was not to fill an order from the city. So why did he do it, as a religious exercise or duty? But what would he copy? It seems to me most likely that he would copy an aged exemplar that was showing signs of wear, to preserve its text. I will demonstrate below that the MSS produced in a single monastery were based on distinct exemplars (as Lake, Blake and New indicated some 85 years ago).¹

Mt. Athos

I have heard it said that the MSS at Mt. Athos are under suspicion of having been mass produced, and of being made to conform to an arbitrary standard. I suspect that the speaker was not aware that there are a number

reflect a very strong consensus, and yet most have private profiles.

¹ K. Lake, R.P. Blake and Silva New, “The Caesarean Text of the Gospel of Mark”, *Harvard Theological Review*, XXI (1928), 348-49.